

A Quick Week

T.S

Civilians of a galactic empire are transported to a historical time period and are forced to engage with a cruel dilemma.

Day 2 of 7

I was walking down the busy Manhattan street when I heard the gunshot.

It was loud. It was sudden. And when I spied the body, it was bloody. The close proximity of the revolver had systematically exploded the head. In response, 2nd Street was still.

Everyone had stopped. Cars, cyclists, pedestrians. The city that never sleeps took a second of silence to bemoan the deceased. It felt empowering that we, as a collective, took the time to honour the dead. It was so rare these days to even believe you had a second for someone else. What were the people around me thinking? Were they sad? Guilty? Thankful it wasn't them?

I knew what I was. I closed my eyes, and instinctively my hand crept up behind my head, fingers curling around the cold metal. My head pounded with the knowledge that a muscle spasm could end my life in an instant. It filled me with exhilaration.

Only for a second. The rest of the time I was brimming with dread. I pulled my hand away, knowing that I still had the whole day to see if my life ended.

This early on in the Tweek, I didn't have the courage to be an 'uppie' yet. Instead, I moved on, my slow trudge a symptom of my scarred thoughts. I heard excited yells when people on the street took inspiration from the deceased and survived.

I flinched badly when I heard two gunshots. Two people had failed.

I didn't stop though. I don't think many other people did either. On the first day we lamented every single death.

Now it just reminded us of where our future was most likely headed.

Day 4 of 7

I am immortal. All humans are. There is no starvation, our skin is like iron and able to withstand atomic force. We can even change our bodies with impunity, people centuries old can have the flesh of a child, the arms and legs of an animal or exist in the strong metal of a robot.

Life is infinite. Peace reigns in a society that spans over the cosmos. There is no crime. How can there be when violence, pain and suffering is all but extinct.

All ... but.

Humans have always found a way to come up with some form of horror. That is why there is the Tweek. Every week, the population of a city in history is recreated and occupied by millions of humans around the galaxy. They are randomly chosen. There is no letter, no notification, one night you go to sleep, and the next morning you wake up somewhere else, stranded with other unlucky souls. I woke up in Manhattan.

I knew exactly what was happening as soon as I awoke.

I had put my hand to the back of my head and felt a sharp fear in my gut.

There was a revolver strapped to the back of my head.

Everyone in the Tweek has one, it's a part of us, a heavy metal barrel, cocked, ready to fire and blow our brains to smithereens.

And this, this will execute us, our everlasting future becoming bloody and finite.

They say it's to curb overpopulation. Whose 'they'? The Empire, the Spacial Media, my own mouth when around the dinner table, discussing something that I never thought would ever happen to me.

Now that I'm here, I can't believe the barbarism. Do you know that not only is there a revolver pointed at my skull, but I am the one who has to pull the trigger? Every morning for this seven-day week, a bullet is implanted within the barrel, which spins and then locks itself in place for the day.

When the pistol is fired, the bullet will disappear. Whether it comes out of the barrel or not.

That's it. It's quite simple really. Those with black humour call it a holiday; you get to live for a week in a moment of history, with unlimited money and the power to do whatever you want.

"I want to live in Ancient Rome! With the Dinosaurs! In the 25th century Martian Catalan!"

I got late 20th Century New York. Isn't it just exciting. Especially considering that I don't actually have to fire the revolver during the day. Nothing is forcing me.

It just means that tomorrow, there will be two in the chamber. The day after, three. They only disappear when fired. There are many folk tales about the survivors. I heard that one Tweek was set deep in the Catacombs of Paris and they let everyone who kept all six in the chamber survive. Something about the darkness being enough of a terror for them.

Rumour has it that the next Tweek, everyone who kept the six not only had their head remotely exploded, but five others for their arrogance.

There weren't many survivors that Tweek.

I'm in my room, late at night, my fingers curling around the trigger. I've survived three in a row. How good is my luck?

With a scream, I fire.

Day 5 of 7

What are the probabilities of playing Russian Roulette for seven days straight? The mathematics is not intuitive.

It's not $1/6$ times 7. No, as that would mean there is only a $1/42$ chance of shooting yourself. Nor can it be $7/6$, you're not guaranteed to fire.

Would you believe it if I told you that one Tweek, not a single person died? Everyone, despite the almost impossible probabilities, fired seven times and made it out alive?

Does it make your heart grow? Do you smile with how many souls were saved by an act so improbable, it could only have occurred through divine intervention, the golden hand of god touching every single brow of the survivors?

What if it happened the other way? What if everyone died? That the last human involved in the Tweek was crying, alone on the seventh day, until he blew himself away.

An abhorrent image, yet it has the same probability.

The likelihood of you dying within seven days is ~72%, or more technically, $1-(5/6)^7$.

Stark odds.

Would you play? Think about rolling a die. You roll it seven times; all you have to do is avoid a One. Are you thinking about the probability, or the outcome?

When I touch the metal behind my head, all I am thinking of is the bloody result. It's only when I survive, that I start thinking about the probability.

Would you do it if you won all the money in the world? A one in six chance sounds pretty good when you can win everything you ever wanted.

Tomorrow, its only one in six that I die.

Only one in six. The odds seem a lot more dire when I can feel the metal on my bare skull.

Tonight, I go out for dinner to a fancy restaurant that serves steak and wine, golden cutlery extravagant on the red tablecloth. It was delicious, a pleasant time until one lady blew her brains out all over her meal.

I wonder if she was thinking 'one in six'.

Day 6 of 7

It's almost over.

The surviving populace has grouped up into 'uppies' and 'downers', that is, you are labelled by what time of the day you decide to fire the shot. If you do it in the morning, you're an 'uppie'. 'Uppies' are happy and cheerful, utilising the pleasures of New York to the utmost with a smile and bountiful energy. They greet the day with ecstasy.

Everyone else is a 'downer'. They spend the day like sloths, a storm cloud hanging over their head, trying to avoid the task ahead of them for as long as possible.

Every night I've been shook awake at 11:59pm; there are so many explosions that at this point I don't even try to go to sleep.

Not to mention that most nights, there was a one in six chance I would join them.

I tried being an 'uppie' once. On the third day, without thinking, I woke up, walked myself to the bathroom, and shot myself in the head in front of the mirror. The click had been magical.

I had a wonderful start to the day. Lost in a rollercoaster of euphoria I danced and celebrated in the morning, going to theatre plays and grungy nightclubs. By midday, reality started to sink in, and I was paralysed by the afternoon.

I knew that tomorrow I would have to do it again.

Every other day I've been a 'downer'. I'd prefer to live for as long as I can, even if my hours are spent thinking about taking the shot.

It's almost midnight. I just can't do it tonight. My hands are sweaty and trembling. Every day it just gets worse. It's still one in six, but this time, I feel like it will be the end of me. I can't do it. Should I just risk having two in the chamber on the last day?

I don't know what to do. I'm hyperventilating.

I can't do this again, I just can't. Why, why do I have to do this. It's sick, its torture, fuck you all I can't do this...

I fire.

Day 7 of 7

The last day. Over the course of this horror, the people involved in the Tweek have made some sort of community. The final survivors.

Everyone is out on the street this cold, snowy afternoon. The weather has changed to the extreme, almost like we went through all four of the seasons in the short time we have been here.

People have begun rituals. They circle around an individual and begin chanting, their voices reaching a fever pitch as the person in the middle makes the decision to risk it one final time. We cheer regardless of a click or an explosion.

The people around me are not historically accurate for 20th century Manhattan. Differences in race, cybernetics and ages.

One day I saw a baby crawling around, the revolver bobbing up and down with its small bald head. Now, there is every chance that baby has lived a life spanning centuries, but that's not the point. There could be real children here. Being young doesn't matter. Nothing matters in the Tweek.

After standing outside for a while watching my peers, I head back to my room. I want to take the shot in private.

I don't know why I am here.

What was my crime? Existence. When no one can die, there is no crime.

Except, wanting to survive.

Well, I don't care anymore. Why do I want to be a part of a world, a galaxy, that allows this to occur? The words sound hollow even in my head.

I sit on the mattress and for one last time, I curl my fingers around the trigger. I've done this so many times already.

It's easy.

I can survive the Tweek.

It's only one in six. How often do you really roll snake eyes?

I fire.

The answer is, more often than you think.

The End